

THE MAN: LATE DR. ABDURRAHMAN MORA (1916–1997)

Late Dr. Abdurrahman Mora was born in 1916. At the age of 30, in 1946, he was among the first four (4) most educated Northerners in Northern Nigeria at the time.

The young Abdurrahman Mora, at the age of 19, attended Katsina Higher College, Katsina, from 1933 to 1938. Between 1945 and 1946, he attended the University of London, United Kingdom. The other three (3) Northerners were the late Alhaji (Sir) Abubakar Tafawa Balewa, the first and only Prime Minister of Nigeria; the late Mallam Yahaya Gusau, *Shettiman* Sokoto; and the late Mallam Bello Kano, *Madakin* Kano.

The man, Abdurrahman, as brilliant as he was, passed the Senior Teacher Certificate in Geography of Wolsey Hall, England, at his first attempt in 1952, becoming the fourth Northern Nigerian to have achieved such success.

In 1952, the American State Department granted Abdurrahman Mora a US scholarship for a six-month fellowship, making him the first Northern Nigerian to be sponsored under the programme (1952/53). No Northern Nigerian had these educational credentials as of 1952/53.

He and some ten (10) of his children and grandchildren attended Barewa College, Zaria, which at other times was called Katsina Higher College, Katsina (1933–1938), and Government College, Zaria (1956–1971). This is the only family in Nigeria with such a high number of graduates of the first public post-primary institution in Northern Nigeria.

Abdurrahman Mora and three (3) of his sons taught at Barewa College, Zaria, for a cumulative period of thirty-five years from 1946 to date. No family in Nigeria has had this number of teachers from the same family teaching in a public school for this number of years and in the same school. Indeed, he himself and one of the two teachers were graduates of Barewa College, Zaria.

Forty-two (42) of his children and grandchildren have attended or are presently studying at Ahmadu Bello University (ABU), Zaria, the highest number from any family in Nigeria. ABU was the first university to be established in the North in 1962. These include three (3) doctors, two (2) pharmacists, three (3) lawyers, four (4) accountants, among others.

EDUCATIONAL ACHIEVEMENTS AND AMERICAN FELLOWSHIP

He was the first Northern Nigerian of his time to be granted a Federal Government scholarship by the United States Information Service (USIS) under an American Fellowship programme.

He presented a report entitled **“Teacher Training Fellowships in the United States of America: 1952/53”** and was among 300 other teachers from 49 countries of the British colonies. His group was assigned to Iowa Teachers' College, Des Moines, State of Iowa. He visited Chicago, New York, New Hampshire and Connecticut.

In 1953, after the six-month fellowship, Mallam Abdurrahman Mora could be said, without any reservations, to have been the most educated Northern Nigerian of his time.

Mallam Abdurrahman Mora authored no fewer than seventeen (17) pamphlets on Islam and Geography according to Islam. They were bound and distributed to neighbours and the children of his deceased friend.

He also edited **“Abubakar Imam Memories” (1989)**, a biography of his very close friend and father-in-law, the late Alhaji (Dr.) Abubakar Imam, OBE, CON, LLD.

CAREER IN EDUCATION AND PUBLIC SERVICE

In the major areas in which he built his career, he rose from an ordinary teacher in the Zaria Middle School after coming to Zaria from Katsina in 1938. He eventually rose to become the Headmaster of the Zaria Middle School in Zaria City for four years, from 1950 to 1954.

Mallam Abdurrahman Mora was an Education Administrator from 1955 to 1959. He can be said to have been one of, if not the best, education administrators in Northern Nigeria.

He was a classroom teacher in Zaria Middle School for seven (7) years. He was seconded to his alma mater, the only public post-primary institution in Northern Nigeria, the Kaduna College, Kaduna (now Barewa College, Zaria), as a teacher for three (3) years from 1947 to 1950.

He became the Headmaster of Zaria Middle School, Zaria, from 1950 to 1954, serving for four (4) years.

In 1954, he was appointed one of the first ten (10) Provincial Education Officers in Northern Nigeria and was assigned to oversee Zaria Province.

The North Regional Government subsequently promoted him to Adult Education Officer (Field Headquarters), Kaduna, from 1955 to 1959, and he became the sole Inspector of Adult Education for the whole of the Northern Region.

It is appropriate to state that, as of 1952, he was probably the most “educated” Northern Nigerian in the education sector, with the following qualifications:

- Katsina Higher College Certificate (1938);
- Professional Teachers' Certificate of the Institute of Education, University of London (1946);
- Senior Teachers' Certificate of Wolsey Hall, England (1950); and
- Fellowship of the American State Department of Iowa State Teachers' College, Cedar Falls, USA (1953).

Later, in 1980, the Government of Kaduna State (comprising present-day Kaduna and Katsina States) appointed him Chairman of a committee for the restoration of discipline in secondary schools in Kaduna State.

In 1983, he was appointed Chairman of the Governing Council of the College of Arts and Science (CAS), Zaria, presently Nuhu Bamalli Polytechnic, Zaria, and served for three (3) years.

He was also the Chairman of the Parent-Teacher Association (PTA) of Government Girls Secondary School, Soba, from 1981 to 1988.

DIPLOMATIC CAREER

He was the Pilgrims Officer and Chargé d'Affaires at the Nigerian Embassy in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, and later became First Secretary at the Embassy when diplomatic relations were opened between Nigeria and Saudi Arabia.

He also rose to become Nigeria's High Commissioner, which is the highest position in the diplomatic career, in the Islamic Republic of Pakistan from 1967 to 1971.

He was also Senior Assistant Secretary (Supernumerary) in the Regional Ministry of Health, Kaduna, and was eventually seconded to the Central (Federal) Government and posted to Lagos, where he took charge of the Federal Ministry of Lagos Affairs as Permanent Secretary.

He later served as Permanent Secretary, Ministry of Internal Affairs.

INVOLVEMENT IN TEACHERS' ASSOCIATION AND EDUCATIONAL DEVELOPMENT

He was an active member of the pan-Northern Teachers' Association (NTA). He started as Assistant Secretary in 1948. In 1950, he became Secretary-General of the NTA.

He also served as a member of the Zaria Province Discipline and Library Committees, the Northern Regional Board of Education, the Northern Nigerian Moral Standard Committee, and the Executive Committee of the Northern Regional Boys' Scout Council.

He was also a member of the Central Board of Education in Lagos, as well as a member of the West African Examinations Council (WAEC), Lagos.

Mallam Abdurrahman Mora was the brain behind the transplantation of the Parent-Teacher Association (PTA) idea into the school system in Northern Nigeria from the mid-1950s. Igbobi College, Lagos, was the first to establish a PTA in Nigeria in 1955.

He was one of the ten (10) Provincial Education Officers for the North and was posted to Zaria Province in 1954.

The North Regional Government promoted him to Adult Education Officer (Field Headquarters), Kaduna, from 1955 to 1959, where he became the sole Inspector of Adult Education for the whole of the Northern Region.

FAMILY AND EDUCATIONAL LEGACY

No fewer than eleven (11) members of his children and grandchildren are presently engaged, or have been engaged, as teachers or have served as teachers in tertiary/related institutions and secondary schools in Nigeria.

One of his sons is a Professor of Pharmacy, while a grandson is a Professor of Medicine. Two (2) others have PhDs, while two (2) have postgraduate fellowships in Pharmacy and Medicine.

Fifty-nine (59) children from his household and neighbouring households in Tudun Wada, Zaria, completed the recitation of the Glorious Qur'an in the sitting room of his residence at 23/25 Mora Road, under his guidance, from 1971, when he retired after having served as Nigeria's High Commissioner to the Islamic Republic of Pakistan (1967–1971), until his death in 1997.

Forty-two (42) of his children and grandchildren attended or are presently studying at Ahmadu Bello University (ABU), Zaria, the highest number from any family in Nigeria. ABU was the first university to be established in the North in 1962.

Among them are three (3) doctors, two (2) pharmacists, three (3) lawyers, four (4) accountants, among others.

He and some ten (10) of his children and grandchildren attended Barewa College, Zaria, formerly known at different times as Katsina Higher College, Katsina (1933–1938), and Government College, Zaria (1956–1971). This represents an exceptional family educational legacy, with such a high number of graduates from the first public post-primary institution in Northern Nigeria.

Abdurrahman Mora and three (3) of his sons taught at Barewa College, Zaria, for a cumulative period of thirty-five years from 1946 to date. No family in Nigeria

has had this number of teachers from the same family serving in a public school for such a long period and in the same school. Indeed, he himself and one of the two teachers were graduates of Barewa College, Zaria.

ZARIA EDUCATION DEVELOPMENT ASSOCIATION (ZEDA)

In 1992, the Zaria Education Development Association (ZEDA), a community-based educational association, was formed by some youths of Zazzau Emirate. Abdurrahman Mora was unanimously appointed the first Chairman of the Board of Trustees (BOT) of the association at its inception.

He held the position until 19 May 1997, when he died.

ZEDA represented the first community-based educational enterprise in the North, and his appointment as its first Chairman of the Board of Trustees reflected the confidence placed in his experience, integrity and lifelong commitment to education.

FINAL YEARS AND LEGACY

After retiring in 1971, following his service as Nigeria's High Commissioner to the Islamic Republic of Pakistan from 1967 to 1971, Mallam Abdurrahman Mora continued to dedicate himself to education, religion, community development and the intellectual growth of younger generations.

From 1971 until his death in 1997, fifty-nine (59) children from his household and neighbouring households in Tudun Wada, Zaria, completed the recitation of the Glorious Qur'an under his guidance at his residence at 23/25 Mora Road.

His life represented an extraordinary combination of education, public service, diplomacy, religious commitment, community development and family mentorship.

From his early years at Katsina Higher College, through his educational and professional achievements in the United Kingdom and the United States, his career as an educator and administrator, his diplomatic service in Saudi Arabia and Pakistan, his contributions to educational development in Northern Nigeria, and his mentorship of children and grandchildren, Late Dr. Abdurrahman Mora left behind a remarkable legacy.

He passed away on 19 May 1997.

May Allah forgive his shortcomings and grant him permanent residence in Aljannah Firdausi. *Amin*.

Written by Abdul-Razak Mustapha Lawal

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